

Pahankanuwa Sermon #2

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

Author: Ven. Katukurunde Nanananda Thero

(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Kumbhūpamaṃ kāyamimaṃ veditvā, nagarūpamaṃ cittamidaṃ
ṭhapetvā; Yodhetha māraṃ paññāvudhena, jitañca rakkhe anivesano
siyā.*

From:

Verse 40 from the Cittavagga (Chapter on the Mind) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

The Blessed One has on many occasions presented the spiritual effort to escape from this extremely terrifying suffering (*dukkha*) of *saṃsāra* as a battle against Mara—a warfare with Mara. We must reflect a little on why the Blessed One introduces this concept of Mara, putting the concept of a battle into our minds. Generally, for the practicing devotees (*yogāvacara*) who begin meditation to free themselves from this suffering (*dukkha*) of *saṃsāra*, numerous obstacles present themselves from both outside and within. Faced with these obstacles, the meditating yogi often becomes weak-minded, discouraged, and hesitant. It is to eliminate that tendency to hesitate and to make them courageous that the Blessed One presented this battle against defilements as a warfare with Mara. The reason for this is that bringing out the combative nature inherent within the human mind helps to strengthen the mind in times when it becomes discouraged and hesitant. That is why, in various places in the Buddha's teachings, amazing battle cries and slogans of the warfare with Mara are mentioned. It is such a verse, like a battle slogan, that we have chosen as our theme on this occasion.

The occasion that led the Blessed One to deliver this verse is recorded in the scriptures as follows. During the time the Blessed One was residing at Jetavana monastery in Sāvattthī, five hundred monks practicing insight meditation, having obtained meditation subjects (*kammaṭṭhāna*) from the Blessed One, departed for a distant village with the intention of practicing insight in a suitable and comfortable place. Having arrived at that place—a certain village—while the monks were walking through, the faithful lay people of that village inquired about the monks' intentions. Upon understanding that they were searching for a place suitable for meditation, they invited them, saying, "There is a very secluded forest grove nearby. Venerable Sirs, please reside there during these three months of the rains retreat. This will be an excellent opportunity for us to observe the precepts and develop faith in the Triple Gem." Thus, they extended an invitation.

In accordance with that invitation, these monks entered the secluded forest grove. The tree deities inhabiting the trees in that grove, out of respect for the virtue of these moral monks and reflecting on the majesty of their virtue (*sīla*), thought, "It is not proper for us to stay high up while these venerable ones are on the ground," and so they descended from the trees. They assumed that these monks would only spend that single night there. However, having gone to the village for alms, the monks returned to the same spot the next day. Then, the deities realized they would have to remain on the ground continuously. As the monks continued to stay day after day, the deities realized that these monks might remain there for several months. Then they thought, "We must drive these monks away by some means. Otherwise, we won't be able to climb back up or live in our trees." So, what did they do? They began to display various forms in the places where the monks meditated. They showed terrifying sights, such as headless corpses, and made non-human noises around the walking meditation paths to frighten the monks. Due to the fear that arose in their minds, the monks could not sleep properly and became ill, each monk suffering from a different ailment. As they discussed this among themselves, each disclosing the visions they had seen, they concluded, "This is not a suitable place for us. This place is infested with non-human disturbances. We must go and find another place. But first, we must inform the Blessed One of this matter." Thus, they returned to the Blessed One.

The Blessed One asked, "Monks, why have you returned?" Then they explained, "We are facing these kinds of afflictions and troubles." But the Blessed One said, "Monks, nevertheless, you must go back to that very place. That indeed is the best place for you." The monks pleaded again, "Venerable Sir, we simply cannot go back there." Then the Blessed One said, "Monks, you went there unarmed. This time, depart fully armed with a proper weapon."

Then those monks asked, "What, O Blessed One, is that weapon?" That weapon was what the Blessed One then expounded as the *Metta Sutta*. For the first time, for the sake of those monks, the Blessed One delivered this *Metta Sutta*, which is of immense benefit to the world. The Blessed One advised those monks, "Memorize this *Metta Sutta*, and as you enter that forest grove, chant it from afar as you go in. Practice it constantly." The monks did exactly as instructed; they entered the forest grove chanting it from the very moment of their approach. Depending on that *Karaṇīyametta Sutta*, they developed a mind of loving-kindness (*mettā*). By the power of that loving-kindness, the hearts of the deities who had previously harassed them softened—it is recorded that, far from troubling them, they even came forward to welcome them, perform various duties for them, and even arranged for their protection. Those non-human noises and various apparitions completely ceased. An environment was created in which the monks could meditate comfortably and calm their minds. The minds of the venerable ones became concentrated, aided by the concentration of loving-kindness (*mettā-samādhi*). Once concentrated, the venerable ones then directed their minds toward insight (*vipassanā*). Reflecting on this cage of a body, realizing that it is like a fragile clay pot, all five hundred monks began to develop insight, contemplating its unstable nature, its impermanent (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*) nature.

At this juncture, the Blessed One, residing many leagues away at Jetavana monastery, observed these monks. It is a unique feature of the Blessed One that no matter where or how far those monks were whom He had sent after giving meditation subjects, He could encompass them in His net of Buddha-knowledge. Because He possessed an extraordinary Buddha-knowledge that no modern machine could ever replicate, the Blessed One constantly kept watch over how the minds of His disciples to whom He had given meditation subjects were functioning. Thus, He saw that all five hundred of them had now entered the path of insight, and their thoughts were directed in that direction. Based on the very theme they had initiated—the meditation subject of the clay pot which they had taken to heart—the Blessed One then uttered the verse we mentioned at the beginning. So meaningful was this verse, and so many deep aspects of meditation were contained within it, that upon hearing it, those monks are said to have attained Arahantship together with the four analytical knowledges (*paṭisambhidā*). Let us now recall that verse once again:

Kumbhūpamaṃ kāyamimaṃ veditvā

Nagarūpamaṃ cittamidaṃ ṭhapetvā

Yodhetha māraṃ paññāyudhena

Jitañca rakkhe anivesano siyā

“*Kumbhūpamaṃ kāyamimaṃ veditvā*” — Knowing and understanding that this body, this physical frame, is comparable to a clay pot.

“*Nagarūpamaṃ cittamidaṃ t̥hapetvā*” — Keeping this mind of ours in a state comparable to a fortified city, treating it as a city that must be guarded.

“*Yodhetha māraṃ paññāyudhena*” — Fight against Mara with the weapon of wisdom.

“*Jitañca rakkhe anivesano siyā*” — Having fought and won a victory, protect that win. However, “*anivesano siyā*” means do not get attached to, wallow in, or settle down in what has been won. Do not just stop there—this special advice is also contained in this verse.

Thus, this is an extremely deep verse. Particularly for those who turn to meditation, we can reveal a vast number of highly important instructions from this verse and from its background story.

Now, if we reflect on that background story for a moment, it shows that those venerable ones went there with the intention of developing insight (*vipassanā*) and realizing Nibbāna. However, although the venerable ones were perfect in virtue (*sīla*), they had a certain deficiency on the side of concentration (*samādhi*)—that is, on the side of serenity (*samatha*). That is to say, they had not properly practiced the meditation of loving-kindness. It must have been due to this deficiency in loving-kindness (*mettā*) that they had to face such great disturbances. Subsequently, it was through the benefits of the instructions given by the Blessed One in the *Karaṇīyametta Sutta* that they were able to concentrate their minds. In this connection, we must remember that the Blessed One has pointed out eleven benefits as the advantages of the meditation of loving-kindness. These venerable ones must have experienced many of those eleven benefits. Namely:

* *Sukhaṃ supati* — One who develops loving-kindness sleeps happily.

* *Sukhaṃ paṭibujjhati* — One wakes up happily with a refreshed mind.

* *Na pāpakaṃ supinaṃ passati* — One does not see evil or terrifying dreams.

* *Manussānaṃ piyo hoti* — One is dear to human beings.

* *Amanussānaṃ piyo hoti* — One is dear to non-human beings.

* *Devatā rakkhanti* — Devas protect him.

* *Nāssa aggi vā viṣaṃ vā satthaṃ vā kamati* — Fire, poison, or weapons do not harm the body of one who practices loving-kindness.

* *Tuvatāṃ cittaṃ samādhīyati* — The mind concentrates quickly.

* *Mukhavanno vipasīdati* — One's facial complexion becomes clear and bright.

* *Asammūḷho kālaṃ karoti* — One dies unconfused; that is, one dies with clear mindfulness.

* *Uttariṃ appaṭivijjhanto brahmalokūpago hoti* — If one does not penetrate higher and attain Arahantship, at the very least, by the power of that *mettā* absorption (*jhāna*), one is reborn in the Brahma world. Thus, the Blessed One has shown these eleven benefits.

It was in accordance with these benefits that the disturbances previously suffered by those monks due to terrifying visions were appeased, and they were able to satisfy and calm their minds.

Thus, we can see the value of serenity (*samatha*) in the first part of this story. Thereafter, the mind thus satisfied realized the value of insight (*vipassanā*). Put another way, one must not be satisfied with serenity (*samatha*) alone. Therefore, the one who has developed serenity should next turn toward insight. For the highest result that can be obtained during the era of a Buddha's appearance is the realization of the Paths and Fruits—seeing Nibbāna. Therefore, in that manner, they turned from serenity to insight. At that moment, they reflected on their own bodies and compared them to a clay pot.

Indeed, what is meant by formations (*saṅkhāra*) is the preparations made by our minds, the accumulation of karma, and so forth. There is an extremely deep meaning within the word *saṅkhāra*. It is through such forces operating within the mind itself that even this cage of our body is created. Next, what is specifically expressed here is the breakable, disintegrating nature of formations (*saṅkhāra*). They break apart moment by moment. This cage of a body, which we regard as something solid, real, and great, is decaying from within at a speed that is almost invisible to us—moment by moment. Because of the ordinary worldling's attachment to form (*rūpa*), this is not understood. But as the yogi's mind becomes increasingly stilled and subtle, he understands how this body disintegrates according to the moment-to-moment changes occurring within it. He realizes that a multitude of arisings (*jāti*) and passings away are operating within this bodily machine. Consequently, the understanding dawns on him that

just as a potter molds a clay pot, this cage of a body and all other things are constructed by formations (*saṅkhāra*).

Thus, especially here, in accordance with mindfulness of the body (*kāyagatāsati*), the disintegrating nature of the body is understood. Generally, worldlings possess a perception of permanence (*nicca-saññā*) regarding this cage of a body. The root of all attachment and binding is this very cage of a body. That was the moment when those monks realized that such a body can be compared to a breakable clay pot or a vessel. It was at that very moment that the Blessed One preached that verse in that manner. Now let us examine the deep meanings contained in this verse, one by one.

“*Kumbhūpamaṃ kāyamimaṃ veditvā*” — Having understood this body to be like such a clay pot. Yet, most of the time, ordinary worldlings commit various evil deeds for the sake of this body. Forgetting that this body is breakable, that it decays moment by moment, and that no matter how much effort is made or how much comfort is provided, it must be abandoned around a hundred years of age or a little beyond, many people commit evil deeds solely for the sake of this body. Indeed, it might have been because even those monks gave too much prominence to the body that they became afraid and declared, "We cannot go back there anymore." You all know very well that if a soldier going to war remains attached to his body, he cannot fight. It is in this very way that the Blessed One presents this concept of warfare with Mara to the practicing yogi (*yogāvacara*). If the yogi prioritizes pampering this body and protecting it, he can never succeed in his spiritual life.

The soldier going to battle makes self-sacrifice for its sake. One who steps into a rapid river with the determination of "either death or crossing over" acts with that single-minded resolve: "death or crossing." In the same way, one engages in the task with a life-sacrificing dedication until victory is achieved. That should be the attitude of the yogi. That is why the Blessed One did not send them elsewhere—He did not say, "Then, monks, let me find a better place for you where there are no such troubles," but instead told them to return to that very place. However, the difference lies in what the Blessed One gave as the weapon for this battle against Mara. That is what we must truly reflect upon during this time.

When we think of war, a massive pile of weapons comes to our minds. We think of the standard weaponry of the respective eras of the world. But when those monks asked, "Venerable Sir, what is the weapon we should take?" the Blessed One presented loving-kindness (*mettā*). It was with that weapon that they stilled their minds. That is what we must reflect upon. Through that, the side of serenity (*samatha*) was fulfilled for those monks, and they learned a lesson: we

must make a sacrifice if we are to escape from *saṃsāra*. The realization must have dawned on those monks that if we start working while holding onto this body, trying to protect this breakable clay pot, we can never realize Nibbāna. That is why, as soon as their minds became concentrated, those venerable ones directed their minds to insight (*vipassanā*).

Thus, “*Kumbhūpamaṃ kāyamimaṃ viditvā*.” Confirming the very thought of those monks, the Blessed One spoke further, encouraging them to make use of that realization. Having understood that this body is like a breakable clay pot, then: “*Nagarūpamaṃ cittamidaṃ t̐apetvā*” — what truly must be guarded, like a fortified city, is this mind. The value of guarding this mind is expressed in the next line. Keeping this mind in that state as a city to be guarded, then—

“*Yodhetha māraṃ paññāyudhena*” — there comes the battle cry. Fight against Mara with the weapon of wisdom. Earlier, He gave the weapon of loving-kindness for serenity (*samatha*). Now He says to battle with Mara using the weapon of wisdom. And then: “*Jitañca rakkhe anivesano siyā*” — if you have fought and won something, protect it. But do not settle down there. Do not cling to it and stop there. Do not be attached to it. In those two lines, a highly practical piece of advice is contained, especially for meditating yogis. Then, “*Yodhetha māraṃ*” — who is this Mara? Who is the Mara that can be fought with the weapon of wisdom?

When we say "Mara", various forms might come to mind from different pictures one has seen. But if we reflect deeply, the real Mara for the practicing yogi (*yogāvacara*) is thought—known as *vitakka* (thought/reflection). Behind this Mara of thoughts (*vitakka*), a massive army of Mara flows in. If we reflect on our own minds, we can see how our mind operates, especially when we fall into defilements (*kilesa*). How rapidly does a stream of thoughts (*vitakka*) flow in? Submerged by them, through our actions, we get entangled in a heap of great sins and head towards hell, the animal realm, and so forth. Thus, Mara is this very thought (*vitakka*). The army of Mara is the army of thoughts (*vitakka*). So, one must fight this Mara with the weapon of wisdom.

What is this weapon of wisdom? Let us reflect on that next. If we consider it deeply, the weapon of wisdom refers to a special task that the practicing yogi (*yogāvacara*) has to perform. What is it? 'Contemplation' or 'attention'. It is called *manasikāra* (attention). It is through contemplating how our mind operates—all these things—that wisdom is developed. Because, through contemplation, the momentum of those thoughts (*vitakka*) is broken. By understanding each arising thought as "this is this, that is that" with mindfulness, clear comprehension (*sati-sampajañña*), and awareness, one realizes their true

nature. In that moment, the rapidly running stream of thoughts (*vitakka*) is suppressed.

Therefore, to manage the stream of thoughts flowing into the mind and not let them wander aimlessly, one must contemplate to fight against Mara—the Mara of thoughts. If anger arises: "Here is an angry mind." Similarly, contemplating the objects that enter through the six doors of the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind right at those very places. The action relevant to the insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*) that a yogi has to perform is contemplation. It is the contemplation of formations (*saṅkhāra*). Thinking of these as formations (*saṅkhāra*)—the very term *saṅkhāra* implies that they are disintegrating things. Instead of taking what disintegrates as permanent (*nicca*), through contemplation one sees how they arise, exist for a brief moment—even for a mere split second—and then pass away. They come, exist, and disappear. To see this nature of arising (*jāti*) and passing away within one's own mind-stream is indeed the fundamental work of insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*). Thus, the contemplation and attention (*manasikāra*) that performs this is what is presented here as wisdom. In truth, the ultimate purpose of insight meditation is the understanding of these phenomena of Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). Our understanding of the entire world is gained by properly understanding these phenomena of Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*).

The mental phenomena (Name) are things anyone can identify just by looking at the mind. There is no need for a strange word for feeling (*vedanā*). Everyone knows feeling (*vedanā*) includes not only pleasant feeling and painful feeling but also neutral feeling—all of them. Perception (*saññā*)—recognition. One can call them perceptions. Based on feeling (*vedanā*), various perceptions are formed. Then, based on perceptions, intentions (*cetanā*) arise—various intentions. Everyone knows what intention is. Next, contact (*phassa*). A sense of contact (*phassa*) arises where things impinge. Then there is attention (*manasikāra*)—contemplation. These five mentioned phenomena are often taken as mental phenomena (Name). Next, what are shown as material phenomena (Form) are earth, water, fire, and wind (*pathavī, āpo, tejo, vāyo*)—the four great elements (*mahābhūta*) out of which our body and external things are composed. It is their combination that miraculously conjures up and displays various forms (*rūpa*). These four 'ghosts' (elements) are the ones that create and show forms. If one understands these few points, it is as if one has understood the entire world. What helps us escape from *saṃsāra* is the understanding of these phenomena of Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*).

In this context too, among these phenomena, attention (*manasikāra*)—the contemplation that comes at the end—is extremely important. It is through that

very contemplation that these are understood. Right there lies the great marvel. If we need an analogy, we can compare these five mental factors to the fingers on our hand. Now, feeling (*vedanā*) is like the little finger. Next, the ring finger, the finger on which rings are worn, is like perception (*saññā*), representing various recognitions. Next, the middle finger is like intention (*cetanā*) \[*note: Sinhala text reads 'feeling' again, but contextually refers to intention*\], the index finger is like contact (*phassa*), and if we take it that way, the thumb is attention (*manasikāra*). So, it is dominant and essential. This thumb—as is evident to everyone—can touch and know the state of the little finger. Similarly, it can know the state of the other fingers as well when needed. It is only when the thumb moves close to the little finger that contact (*phassa*) occurs between them. The same applies to the other fingers. Thus, even though the thumb stands apart, it is the leader, the chief. It is with the help of this thumb that the entire group of Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*) is identified.

It is just like when a gang commits a crime and there is no witness to testify; what does the court sometimes do? They grant a pardon to one of the perpetrators themselves. The pardon is given on the condition: "You must speak the truth. Only if you tell the truth will you be pardoned." Then, when that person comes forward and tells the truth, he himself is implicated. But the case is proven. In the same way, we use one of these five mental factors to understand these phenomena of Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). We use this very contemplation (attention) as our aid. However, it is not unwise attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*) or wrong contemplation. It is proper contemplation—wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*). That is to say, like a thief in that gang who was initially a thief, once he starts testifying, he testifies as a state witness. In the same way, preventing unwise attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*), one directs the mind to wise contemplation.

Thus, applying wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*) in this way allows one to understand the true nature of things through wisdom, attention (*manasikāra*), and contemplation. Furthermore, through that very contemplation, one gets the opportunity to recognize those elements—earth, water, fire, and wind (*pathavī, āpo, tejo, vāyo*). Through contact (*phassa*), one understands them as hardness, softness, and so on. This is the fundamental practice of insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*). Therefore, this is the weapon that helps conquer the armies of Mara: attention (*manasikāra*)—contemplation—wise contemplation.

Just like with any weapon—say in a sword fight—one must wield one's sword with great speed to block the enemy's strikes. Similarly, in the practice of attention (*manasikāra*), contemplation must be as fast and rapid as possible, if one is to

win this battle against Mara. So, meditation teachers show this method of speeding up according to the occasion—in the beginning, one contemplates these as "form, form", "sound, sound", "odor, odor"—and similarly with tastes, fragrances and smells. One contemplates them as "taste, taste" and so on. Even a thought—when a thought arises, recognizing it as "this is a thought"—if an angry thought arises, understanding it as "a thought"—breaks the stream of thoughts (*vitakka*) through that understanding. It is through such rapid contemplation that one can conquer the stream of thoughts (*vitakka*).

“*Yodhetha māraṃ paññāyudhena*”

Next: “*Jitañca rakkhe anivesano siyā*” — an extraordinarily deep meaning is expressed here. What is specifically meant for those monks by the phrase “*jitañca rakkhe*” (protect what is won) here? Generally, as obstacles that arise for a yogi, we can consider attachment to the concentration of loving-kindness (*mettā-samādhi*) that he has attained. These monks had also attained a certain degree of progress in concentration (*samādhi*). Because when concentration (*samādhi*) arises, it is accompanied by a great pleasure—physical pleasure. And they take that to be something great. They think, "This is the great thing, this indeed is the bliss of Nibbāna." There is such a deceptive tendency. They are also called corruptions (*upakkilesa*), or corruptions of insight (*vipassanā-upakkilesa*). When various lights appear, when comfort is felt in the body, when tranquility is felt, when special understandings arise, one grasps all these very tightly. There is a tendency to think, "Now I have seen extinguishment, I have become a Stream-enterer (*sotāpanna*)."

That is why it is said, “*jitañca rakkhe*” (protect what is won). If there is some concentration (*samādhi*) one has attained, one must protect it. However, “*anivesano siyā*” — if one settles down there, one will never be able to reach the state one aspires to. Therefore, do not settle down in them. One must be careful of that. That is specifically the word of the Buddha here. A special instruction that aids meditation subjects (*kammaṭṭhāna*) is mentioned in this verse. Generally, a practicing yogi (*yogāvacara*) falls into delusion if there is no teacher's guidance. The reason for this is that when one experiences physical pleasure and other things never experienced before through concentration (*samādhi*), the mind is tempted to indulge in them. One must prevent that.

To use the war analogy, when a warrior fights, if a real battle is raging, he must also have a fortress. At any point, if his weapon is broken or damaged, or if he needs food and drink, the warrior retreats to that fortress, rests, attends to his needs, and then returns to the battle. But if, upon returning to the fortress, he just goes to sleep there, he can never win that battle. In the same way, there is a

certain necessity for serenity (*samatha*). Serenity (*samatha*) means concentration (*samādhi*). But what is the marvel of the Blessed One's Middle Way? It makes use of everything, but does not grasp even a single thing. It does not settle down in any of them. For it is mentioned in the Dhamma that if one grasps anything in the world, Mara pursues him by way of that very thing:

Yaṃ yaṃ hi lokasmiṃ upādiyanti

Teneve māro anveti jantum

— Sutta Nipāta, 1108

"Whatever they grasp in the world, by that itself Mara pursues a person." It is said that if we grasp even the slightest thing in the world, Mara will chase after us because of it. Such is the nature of the mind. That is what the battle with Mara is. The mind always seeks to roost in formations (*saṅkhāra*), to grasp them. That grasping tendency can only be prevented through that very contemplation. When one contemplates rapidly, that grasping tendency is cut off, and those things slip away through contemplation. One contemplates, and then lets it go—in that manner, by understanding its nature, that delusion is removed; if delusion is present, one is tempted to grasp it entirely. When understanding comes through attention (*manasikāra*) and wisdom, one does not tend to grasp it. Then, its impermanent (*anicca*) nature is realized. One understands that these are things that come and go.

Relying on that, one can then proceed forward on the 'path of insight' (*vipassanā-vīthi*). To advance along the path of insight, the cognitive series of insight (*vipassanā-citta-vīthi*)—which can also be called a cognitive series—one must not get attached to or wallow in what has been won. Using them as aids, employing that power of concentration (*samādhi*), and instead of clinging to them, establishing equanimity (*upekkhā*)—using equanimity as an aid—one should understand the true nature of things. This is the Blessed One's instruction in this verse:

Jitañca rakkhe anivesano siyā

This means do not settle down in them. The nature of this mind is always to build houses. The mind is constantly seeking to build houses. The Blessed One uses the word "*nivesana*" in the sense of a home or dwelling. It is connected to the concept of settling down. Now, if we reflect wisely on the Blessed One's Dhamma—it is just like when we construct a building, we erect scaffolding. We build the scaffolding while constructing the building. But no one should think of living on the scaffolding. If one lives on the scaffolding, the building will never be

completed. One constantly dismantles them and goes higher. The path of the Dhamma is similar to that—that is what the Middle Way is.

Thus, the advice, “*Jitañca rakkhe anivesano siyā*” is an extremely useful point for us, especially for 'yogis'—or those engaged in meditation. Because quite often among meditators, when asked about their results, they happily declare, "I have this and that experience." But they do not realize they have been deluded, overcome by the corruptions of insight (*vipassanā-upakkilesa*): "Look, I see beautiful lights. There is an extraordinary pleasure. I can sit for as long as I want—even for hours." But they have roosted there. They have roosted in that concentration (*samādhi*) they attained. There is no forward progress. That is why it is said, “*anivesano siyā*” — it is through that very contemplation that we can ultimately win this battle. For wherever there is grasping, Mara is right there. Right there, one is subjugated by Mara.

Such a wonderful Dhamma is found here. Thus, in light of that verse, we can understand how important this attention (*manasikāra*) is, which helps to reveal the three characteristics of insight meditation: impermanence (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*). Everything is caught through this very contemplation. Even if it is not expressed in words, when one sees how those formations (*saṅkhāra*) arise, exist for a very brief moment, a split second, and pass away, their impermanent (*anicca*) nature becomes clear. Furthermore, if something is impermanent (*anicca*), if it changes—if it turns upside down, if it breaks apart—no pleasure can be found there. Therefore, its nature of suffering (*dukkha*) is understood. One also understands and directly experiences that taking such a thing as 'I' or 'mine' is foolishness. Thus, to realize those three characteristics through direct experience, that contemplation is of assistance.

In the beginning, as mentioned, contemplation is done as "form, form", "sound, sound", and so on. That is to say, in the ordinary world, names like "there is a car", "there is so-and-so", "a woman", "a man", and further details about those persons are necessary for everyday worldly convention. We cannot do without them. But the insight yogi must transcend them if he is to realize Nibbāna, to become transcendent. In worldly terms, everything that comes along is identified by name. These are called 'signs' (*nimitta*) and 'features' (*anuvyañjana*). We grasp signs regarding what is seen and heard. It is due to the lack of control over those signs that we are submerged in this stream of defilements and undergo various sufferings throughout this long *saṃsāra*. Therefore, to escape from these, the meditating yogi must make a special effort to break the habit of grasping signs. It cannot be broken all at once.

But an aid to this is the recognition called perception (*saññā*). Initially, a certain experience of something occurs, and on that basis, it is recognized. It does not stop there. Then feelings (*vedanā*) arise regarding it, often feelings of anger, or a strong attachment to pleasure. Thus, the true nature of all these can be understood through that attention (*manasikāra*). Reflecting in this way, in attention (*manasikāra*), one tries to understand very briefly—without following after perceptions (*saññā*)—what the ordinary worldling understands through numerous words. One stops right there, identifying it simply as a 'form' or a 'sound'. Something like 'erasing it on the spot' must occur there.

Then, as one proceeds further and develops insight, one has to contemplate even the mere awareness of these. Just the mere awareness of it, stopping right there—that rapid contemplation. Just as we mentioned in a sword fight, when both are fighting equally, if one is to conquer the enemy, one must be strong enough to block at a speed faster than the speed with which the enemy wields his weapon. In the same way, to prevent these thoughts that run with the extraordinary, indescribable speed of Mara's army, this contemplation must be done with equal rapidity. If this contemplation becomes weak, what happens? One is caught by those perceptions (*saññā*).

Perception (*saññā*)—the Blessed One has declared—is a mirage. A mirage means that when one sees it, one chases after it. We take this perception to 'know' it properly. We feel like knowing what this is. For instance, if someone is traveling on a road—say, heading to Colombo. But if on the way, looking around from the vehicle, he tries to see what those beautiful things around him are like and explore them, he will never reach Colombo. If he thinks he must stop and fully examine every single thing he sees wherever his mind wanders—that is the case.

Then one might think, "If we do this, we cannot live in the world, can we?" One can always live in the world if one wishes. But the Blessed One is showing the path to escape from *saṃsāra*. Therefore, the practicing yogi (*yogāvacara*) must especially make an effort to break that habit of grasping signs for the sake of this task—the task of realizing Nibbāna. That is why it is done systematically. It is not a matter of closing one's eyes or shutting one's ears. To guard these senses, one first removes those concepts of 'this person' or 'that thing', discards worldly names, and begins contemplating them simply as 'form' or 'sound'. As one continues and goes deeper, one sees that even this, in some way, is still—even slightly—getting caught in the mirage of perception (*saññā*).

In that way, at a certain point, one can develop the strength to cut off the stream of thoughts right at the stage of mere contact (*phassa*) or mere awareness,

through that very attention (*manasikāra*). It is through that indeed that one can clearly and directly experience the nature of arising (*jāti*) and passing away of formations (*saṅkhāra*), and even progress to states such as the realization of the Paths and Fruits.

Thus, many such matters are contained in this verse. We must reflect that we are living in the extremely rare era of a Buddha's appearance, having obtained a human existence. We hear about 'meditation' all the time, and everyone says they are practicing it. However, the goals of those meditations often do not help in escaping from the suffering (*dukkha*) of *saṃsāra* in the way the Blessed One declared. Often, they are trapped in goals such as soothing the body, obtaining physical health and freedom from disease, seeing pleasant visions, or achieving various other worldly purposes and healing illnesses. Those are indeed instances of 'settling down'.

Instead, what should be done is that if a level of concentration (*samādhi*) is developed through some serenity meditation subject (*samatha-kammaṭṭhāna*), one must contemplate the disadvantages (*ādīnava*) present in that concentration. Everything has its side of gratification and its side of danger—the Blessed One has declared that there are three things in the world: gratification (*assāda*), danger (*ādīnava*), and escape (*nissaraṇa*). There can be a good side to these, but along with it, there are also many dangers (*ādīnava*). Therefore, one must escape from this—"escape" (*nissaraṇa*) means departing from all of these.

In grasping lies becoming (*bhava*). In letting go lies cessation. Understanding this, when one habituates the mind to the nature of arising and passing away in the world, the realization comes: "If I grasp this, I will be overturned along with it and meet destruction." In that way, one does not remain stuck even in that concentration (*samādhi*). Even during the Buddha's time, teachers like Āḷāra Kālāma and Uddaka Rāmaputta, whom the Bodhisatta originally approached as teachers, had reached extremely high states through concentration (*samādhi*) and serenity (*samatha*). But because they clung and settled down in them, they were unable to see Nibbāna.

Thus, the greatest light that the world receives through the appearance of a Buddha is this light of insight (*vipassanā*). It is these very valuable aspects relevant to insight meditation that are contained in this verse. In accordance with this, we must reflect that we should enter this path of Dhamma to the best of our ability, and even in daily life, try to withdraw from these as much as possible. For that, a great sacrifice may sometimes have to be made. What is the reason for this? Now, particularly for lay devotees, a major problem might arise when

practicing insight meditation and similar activities. This complex society is actually running after that mirage of perception (*saññā*). Just like deer running, lured by a mirage, this world—or rather, the worldly-minded who are entirely bent on the mundane—tries to delude people and turn them into madmen. They do this either to sell their wares, or to pull and drag them into other worldly things. It is in the midst of a multitude of such forces that we are living.

In such an era, some bodily seclusion (*kāya-viveka*) is obtained when one observes the precepts, such as on a Uposatha poya day like today. One can keep one's mind aloof from those things. One must increase this habit of keeping the mind aloof. It is through that indeed that renunciation (*nekkhamma*) arises. Thus, in regard to that body, there are three kinds of seclusion: bodily seclusion (*kāya-viveka*), mental seclusion (*citta-viveka*), and seclusion from acquisitions (*upadhi-viveka*). When bodily seclusion occurs, a certain happiness arises from it, but that is not complete. Merely saying "we are in a very quiet place without any noise" does not make it complete. Next, through bodily seclusion, one develops mental seclusion, keeping the mind aloof. Then comes seclusion from acquisitions (*upadhi-viveka*). Abandoning the five aggregates (*pañcakkhandha*) is the final step. Abandoning these five aggregates—these five heaps: form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness (*rūpa, vedanā, saññā, saṅkhāra, viññāṇa*)—which we have been clinging to and carrying through this long *saṃsāra*, is what is done through insight, and this is what is called the realization of Nibbāna.

Why are these called five heaps (aggregates)? The ordinary worldling thinks of this form (*rūpa*) as a single unit, as 'my form'. When we take a photograph, the first thing that usually comes to our mind is, "This is my form." But we do not see the power of change, the speed of change, the constant flux within it. That is why when a friend visits after a long time, they ask, "Oh, how much you have changed!" It did not change just at that moment of seeing, nor did it change suddenly over that period of time. Such is the nature of this form (*rūpa*). In truth, form changes very slowly. But this mind changes even faster. This mind changes with extreme rapidity.

Yet, the entire world is wrapped up in delusion, taking even that mind as a soul (*attā*), as 'I' and 'mine'. This is what is meant by terms like the dogma of self-illusion (*sakkāya-diṭṭhi*). This is regarded as a 'soul' (*attā*). They think: "Form is my soul." The same applies to feeling (*vedanā*). We take feeling (*vedanā*) as a single unit. To us, it suddenly appears as one single thing. But when the insight yogi applies that attention (*manasikāra*) to it, he sees that there is only a

multitude of sparkings and breakages. Feeling (*vedanā*) is like a great series of sparkings that arise and pass away.

One can also understand form (*rūpa*) through the analogy of the clay pot. Similarly, form is something made up of a multitude of elements: earth, water, fire, and wind. Feeling (*vedanā*) too is like that. It is a vibrating event that changes extremely rapidly depending on contact (*phassa*). A multitude of sensations (*vedanā*) are present there—what is called the aggregate of feeling (*vedanā-kkhandha*) is a heap of feelings, not a single one. So how can one say 'I' to a mere heap? They are oppressed by arising (*jāti*) and passing away.

Next, perception (*saññā*)—recognition. That too is a heap of recognitions. Normally, we say we recognized something instantly. In common parlance, we say, "I recognized it at once." It is not all at once; rather, we recognize something through a rapid series of recognitions. We take that entire bundle of recognitions as a single thing. The same is true for intention (*cetanā*). Intention too is extremely rapid. A multitude of intentions are there—a heap of intentions. This is what we call formations (*saṅkhāra*). All these things, including feeling, perception, formations, and intentions, are formations (*saṅkhāra*)—a heap of preparations. A constructive force within the mind. One thinks of such a heap of preparations as 'I' and 'mine'.

An even more serious delusion is this mind—consciousness (*viññāṇa*), the hiding place of this sense of 'I'. Now, we know that after breaking through the enemy's fortresses, the final fortress—like the city of Vijitapura—is consciousness (*viññāṇa*). This is where the greatest magic (illusion) lies. That is why the Blessed One compared this consciousness (*viññāṇa*) to an illusion (magic trick). One cannot easily escape from an illusion. Therefore, the Blessed One declared that if one reflects deeply in daily life even on the analogies He provided for these five aggregates (*pañcakkhandha*), one can realize Nibbāna through that. Form (*rūpa*) is compared to a lump of foam. Feeling (*vedanā*) is compared to a water bubble.

A lump of foam—when we see it, we are tempted to perceive it as a solid unit (*ghana-saññā*). It looks beautiful. But what is there is a multitude of extremely subtle bubbles. Similarly, the Blessed One compared feeling (*vedanā*) to the numerous water bubbles that rapidly arise and burst when rain falls on water. Feeling (*vedanā*) is like a multitude of sparkings. Next, perception (*saññā*) is compared to a mirage. We also mentioned the mirage on this occasion. That is to say, there is no end to recognition. This running to find out what 'this' is—is entirely like the running of a deer after a mirage. In the end, there is nothing

there. It is a dragging illusion. In the end, it terminates in a magical illusion. That is perception (*saññā*).

Next, formations (*saṅkhāra*) are compared to the trunk of a banana tree. A banana trunk has no core, no heartwood. It lacks any essence. There is only a pile of layers. The world has a tendency to take a multitude of formations as a single unit. Thus, these formations (*saṅkhāra*) made by the mind are the heap of thoughts (*vitakka*) passing through the mind. When we reflect ultimately, it is by the mind itself that these are prepared:

“*Manopubbaṅgamā dhammā, manoseṭṭhā manomayā*”

as the word of the Buddha says: mind is the forerunner, mind is chief, mind-made are they. Ultimately, when we look at it, this world is conjured up by the mind itself. Such is the situation. A great marvel is found here, expressed in a way no other religious teacher has ever done.

So then, what is the cause of that delusion? Consciousness (*viññāṇa*) is compared to a magical illusion. When a magician performs a magic trick at a crossroads, in a public place, everyone who watches stands with mouth agape, shouting in amazement, deceived into thinking it is a great wonder. But only the magician knows that it is entirely a deception, showing a heap of things that do not exist. This is exactly like that. It is our mind, our consciousness (*viññāṇa*), that conjures up and displays what is non-existent as if it exists.

This state cannot be understood by the ordinary worldling. It cannot be understood by logic. Scholars cannot understand it through degrees. This must be understood by the wise, each for themselves, according to the phrase: “*Paccattaṃ veditabbo viññūhi*”—through one’s own wisdom. “The wise” (*viññū*) refers to those who possess real wisdom—not merely intellectual pedants. This is something that must be understood by oneself through that insight-wisdom. No one else can do it for you. Not even the Buddha can do it. One must establish oneself in virtue (*sīla*), develop concentration (*samādhi*) to some level, and then—with proper guidance, entering into insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*)—it is through that attention (*manasikāra*) that one can understand the true nature of this illusion of consciousness (*viññāṇa*). And only through this can one escape from this illusion.

This is what is meant by abandoning the five aggregates (*pañcakkhandha*). It is not a matter of grabbing them with one’s hands and throwing them away. If, through this wisdom, one understands the aggregate of form (*rūpa-kkhandha*) as just the aggregate of form, one realizes right then that there is nothing to be grasped, and one does not get caught. One is not trapped into grasping it. The

same applies to feeling (*vedanā*). When the water-bubble analogy is understood, one realizes that there is no core here, nothing worth taking—its unsubstantiality (*anattā*). Perception (*saññā*) is a mirage, and formations (*saṅkhāra*) are a banana trunk.

If someone, thinking there is heartwood in a banana trunk and intending to build a wardrobe, carries the trunk home for the first time—upon examining it and peeling a bit, he finds only another layer beneath. In this way, the insight yogi understands this matter taught by the Blessed One through the word *sammasana* (comprehension/investigation). Comprehension (*sammasana*) is like gently feeling and examining. What the world does is grasping (*parāmāsa*), which is holding on tightly. Relinquishing this habit of tight grasping, contemplating in the extremely subtle way of comprehension (*sammasana*) is what assists insight.

We know that generally when stropping a razor, one holds it lightly, as if it could easily slip out. Holding it in that manner, when sliding the razor up and down on the whetstone, one must do it in a way that does not blunt the edge. It is honed, not blunted. If held too tightly, the razor becomes blunt. Instead, it is by holding it subtly and gliding it back and forth that a razor can be sharpened. In the exact same way, without getting bound to anything—neither to perceptions (*saññā*) nor to feelings (*vedanā*) and so forth—one contemplates each thing as it comes, just like swordplay, and stops right there. It is by proceeding in this manner, through this path of insight, by penetrating the Paths and Fruits of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship, that one can directly experience the supreme, peaceful bliss of Nibbāna, which is called the stilling of all formations (*sabba-saṅkhāra-samatha*).

Thus, in accordance with that teaching of the Buddha, you have received numerous instructions on this Poya day to help you turn toward meditation. One should resolve not to stop at mere hearing, but to enter this path oneself, associating with those who can provide guidance and instructions, and strive to escape from this extremely terrifying suffering (*dukkha*) of *saṃsāra*.

Furthermore, having established yourself in some good virtue (*sīla*) on this occasion, and having listened to this Dhamma teaching with a concentrated and stilled mind, allowing the intellect to understand, I believe that your virtue, concentration, and wisdom (*sīla, samādhi, paññā*) have been developed to some extent. Walking along that path of virtue, concentration, and wisdom, may you develop within your own mind-stream those faculties and powers (*indriya* and *bala*)—namely faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom (*saddhā, viriya, sati, samādhi, paññā*)—which are the benefits of hearing the

Dhamma, as quickly as possible. You should make a resolution and aspire: "May this hearing of the Dhamma assist me in attaining the realization of the supremely peaceful Nibbāna that helps cross over this suffering (*dukkha*) of *saṃsāra* as taught by the Blessed One."

In addition, if there be any store of merit accumulated by us through both preaching and hearing the Dhamma during this time, may all beings from the lowest hell of Avīci to the highest heaven of Akaniṭṭha, including the guardian deities of the Dispensation who rejoice in these merits, share in this store of merit gathered by us on this occasion. Having rejoiced, may they realize the noble, deathless, great Nibbāna through whatever state of awakening (*bodhi*) they aspire to. Likewise, may all departed relatives who have passed away in your names rejoice in this store of merit and obtain the strength to bring an end to suffering! May you aspire in that manner.

Now, on this occasion, let us transfer merits by reciting these verses:

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”